turned to the urbane Shashi Tharoor, aware that he might lend some gravitas to their side in debates. But Tharoor, too, was often tied up in his own election battle in Thiruvananthapuram. ‘Too many news channels, too few credible faces,’ is how a member of the party’s media cell summed up the Congress problem.

The Congress’s plight was exemplified by one of its newer spokespersons, Sanjay Jha. I had met Jha almost a decade ago when he was involved in a cricket website. He struck me as a nice, regular Mumbai guy. He ran a successful leadership training business, was a member of all the right clubs, liked his sport and did the occasional writing.

Suddenly in 2012, I found Jha appearing on television channels as a founder of a website, HamaraCongress.com, designed, he says, to change the Congress’s negligible presence on the Internet. A year later, he was made an official spokesperson of the Congress. Soon, he was speaking on three or even four channels on a single night. It seemed a spectacular rise for someone who had never fought even a local election. ‘Doing multiple shows in a single day can be exacting, but I had the passion for a fight and strongly believed that the Congress is part of India’s DNA, its ethos,’ he told me.

Jha made a valiant attempt, but he often seemed to be a lamb to the slaughter. He had debating skills but on many occasions, he just didn’t have the political weight to take on his more influential counterparts. Do nightly television debates make a difference to the voter? Maybe not. News television, especially English news TV, occupies a very small space in the overall TV universe. But it does add to the surround sound during an elections and has acquired an almost monstrously larger-than-life image in the lives of opinion makers. It can, importantly, set the news agenda. In 2009, I would hear the chattering classes gush over how the Congress had come out looking so strong in the Indo-US nuclear debate on TV. In 2014, the talk was all about how the Congress spokespersons were defending the indefensible, be it 2G or inflation. A senior Congress leader admitted to me, ‘You know, every time Renuka Chaudhary tries to shout and filibuster her way through a debate, we lose another 100 votes!’